

8

Stepping to the Edge of One's Comfort Zone

Cynthia D. McCauley and Paul R. Yost

A ship in harbor is safe, but that is not what ships are built for.
—John A. Shedd (1859–1928), American author and professor

Stretch experiences play a central role in the development of leaders. An experience is stretching to the degree that effective performance in the experience requires knowledge, skills, and perspectives beyond what the individual has currently developed. By taking individuals to the edge of their comfort zone, these experiences offer both the opportunity and the necessity to learn. Also referred to as job challenges or developmental assignments, stretch experiences come in all different sizes. They can range from major changes in a person's responsibilities or context (e.g., a first supervisory job, heading up a new strategic initiative, or an expatriate assignment in a culture very different from one's own) to everyday experiences that are unfamiliar, complex, or high stakes (e.g., organizing a fundraising event for the first time, giving difficult feedback to an employee, or presenting to an important stakeholder group).

The learning agility literature describes the relationship between stretch experiences and learning agility (i.e., an individual's ability and willingness to learn from experience) in multiple ways. Regularly stepping into stretch experiences with the intent to learn and grow is often portrayed as a hallmark of the learning agile individual (Hallenbeck, 2016; Lombardo & Eichinger, 2000); thus, learning agility can be an *antecedent* pointing to who is most likely to pursue stretch experiences. Facets of learning agility are also viewed as a *moderator* of the relationship between stretch experiences and development (Yost & McLellan, 2014). The greater an individual's learning agility,

the more likely he or she will learn from a stretch experience. Yet, learning agility is also regarded as an *outcome* of stretch experiences (Hallenbeck & Santana, 2019). Repeated encounters with stretch experiences can enhance efficacy and skill for learning at the edge of one's comfort zone.

This chapter focuses on how talent management and leadership development professionals encourage and support regularly stepping to the edge of one's comfort zone in ways that stimulate learning and development. We highlight three broad experience-based strategies for enhancing learning agility in organizations: (a) making stretch experiences more visible and valued, (b) getting people into the right stretch experiences for targeted development, and (c) increasing skill and confidence for continuous learning and development at the edge of one's comfort zone.

Our focus is on using stretch experiences for leadership development. However, we do not limit an organization's leader population to those individuals in managerial roles. In today's flatter, highly networked organizations, leadership is a capability needed at all levels throughout an organization. We highlight leadership development practices that can be incorporated into talent management processes, practices that managers can engage in with their direct reports, and scalable, self-reinforcing practices that everyone in an organization can adopt. We ground these strategies and practices in theories of adult learning and in research that looks more specifically at the role of stretch experiences in leadership development.

Stretch Experiences: Theory and Research

Numerous theories of adult learning and development point to experience—purposive interaction with one's environment—as the medium through which growth occurs. For example, experiential learning theory conceptualizes learning as an ongoing cyclical process of engaging in experiences, making observations and reflections on those experiences, forming concepts and generalizations, and testing those ideas in new situations (Kolb, 1984). A number of these theories emphasize experiences that are novel, challenging, or dissonance producing as the stimulus for development. Cognitive theories of learning (Kanfer & Ackerman, 1989) posit that people's knowledge structures grow and develop when they are challenged by novel information obtained via experience. Argyris and Schön (1974) added the concept of double-loop learning in which new information

disrupts people's central assumptions, leading to the examination of those assumptions and the development of new meaning structures. From the perspective of constructive theories of adult development (Kegan, 1994), people develop more complex and adaptive ways of understanding self and the world as they work to make sense of disequilibrating experiences.

Research on developmental experiences in managerial careers also supports the role of stretch experiences in leader development. Across a series of studies, managers most frequently cited challenging assignments as a key driver of their own development (McCall, Lombardo, & Morrison, 1988; Van Velsor, Wilson, Criswell, & Chandrasekar, 2013). Subsequent research identified five major types of challenges that stretched individuals in these assignments: (a) unfamiliar responsibilities, (b) creating change, (c) high levels of responsibility, (d) managing across boundaries, and (e) dealing with diversity (Ohlott, 2004). Job incumbents who report these types of challenges are rated higher on leadership skill development, managerial competencies, and promotability by their supervisors (De Pater, Van Vianen, Bechtoldt, & Klehe, 2009; DeRue & Wellman, 2009; Dragoni, Tesluk, Russell, & Oh, 2009).

As noted, regularly stepping into these stretch experiences is considered a hallmark of the learning agile leader. Measures of learning agility often include items that assess the degree to which an individual seeks new opportunities, welcomes change, and is curious and willing to experiment (Burke, Roloff, & Mitchinson, 2016; De Meuse, Lim, & Rao, 2019; Lombardo & Eichinger, 2000). And, research examining antecedents of stretch assignments finds that individuals with a higher learning goal orientation are more likely than those with a lower learning goal orientation to report currently being in a job that provides challenge (Aryee & Chu, 2012; Preenen, Van Vianen, & De Pater, 2014).

An important caveat to note is that inequities often exist when it comes to who is given the opportunity to take on stretch assignments. Compared to men, women are less likely to be placed in challenging jobs critical for career advancement (e.g., mission-critical roles, international assignments) or be assigned challenging tasks as part of their jobs (King et al., 2012; Silva, Carter, & Beninger, 2012). When describing their developmental experiences, African American managers also do not report as many challenging assignments compared to their white counterparts (Douglas, 2003).

Facets of learning agility have also been studied as a moderator of the relationship between stretch experiences and both learning and performance

outcomes. For example, Dragoni et al. (2009) found that learning goal orientation moderated the relationship between developmental impact of job assignments and supervisor ratings of competencies; the positive relationship was stronger for those with higher levels of learning goal orientation. Moderator studies have been particularly useful in understanding how learning agility decreases the potential negative consequences of stretch experiences. Although Dong, Seo, and Bartol (2014) found that stretch assignments can boost pleasant feelings, which in turn increase advancement potential, they also found that these experiences can increase unpleasant feelings, which are associated with turnover intentions. However, stretch assignments were positively related to turnover intentions only for those managers who were low on emotional regulation (i.e., the ability to detect, respond to, and manage emotions). The researchers argued that emotional regulation can serve as a buffer to prevent unpleasant feelings from developing into intentions to leave one's job. Courtright, Colbert, and Choi (2014) found that stretch assignments were associated with not only higher work engagement but also higher emotional exhaustion. Increased emotional exhaustion led in turn to higher incidents of laissez-faire leadership. This indirect relationship between stretch experiences and laissez-faire leadership held only for those managers with low leadership self-efficacy (i.e., perceptions of one's ability to effectively perform the functions of a leadership role). The researchers encourage organizations to enhance leaders' readiness for stretch assignments by building their self-efficacy through education, mentoring, and coaching.

Finally, learning agility has also been viewed as an outcome of stretch experiences, although little work has directly examined this relationship. Many of the competencies identified as facets of learning agility (e.g., self-insight, resilience, flexibility, and feedback seeking) are those that managers report learning from experience (McCall et al., 1988; Van Velsor et al., 2013). Researchers have also begun to examine the outcomes of stretch experiences from a social cognitive perspective, finding that the increased self-efficacy generated by stretch experiences mediates the relationship between challenging jobs and the incumbent's performance and promotability (Aryee & Chu, 2012; Seibert, Sargent, Kraimer, & Kiazad, 2017).

Research thus supports the view that learning agility is related to stretch assignments in multiple ways: as an antecedent, moderator, and outcome. In other words, learning agile leaders are more likely to seek stretch experiences,

Table 8.1 Facets of Learning Agility Related to Stretch Experiences

Antecedent: Predicts who pursues stretch experiences	Moderator: Moderates stretch-learning or stretch-performing relationship	Outcome: Enhanced by stretch experiences
Change readiness Curious, experimental Learning goal orientation	Emotional regulation Self-efficacy Learning goal orientation	Self-insight Resilience Flexibility Feedback seeking Self-efficacy

learn from them, and use those lessons to improve their performance, in the process enhancing their learning agility. Table 8.1 summarizes the emerging findings about this multifaceted relationship between stretch assignments and learning agility.

Encouraging and Supporting Learning at the Edge

Using learning theory and research-based knowledge on learning from stretch experiences, we now turn to strategies to encourage and support more leaders stepping to the edge of their comfort zone and, in so doing, demonstrate and enhance their learning agility. First, organizations can shine a brighter light on learning from stretch experiences, making this learning more visible and valued. Second, organizations can be more intentional in making the right stretch experiences available for all leaders. Finally, organizations can develop leaders' skill and confidence for continuous learning at the edge of their comfort zones.

Shine a Light on Learning From Stretch Experiences

To encourage stepping to the edge of one's comfort zone, stretch experiences need to be a bigger part of the learning and development conversation in organizations. And, to better leverage these experiences for their own development, leaders benefit from practicing learning from stretch experiences in supportive environments and from seeing the value that their organization places on this approach to development.

Table 8.2 Examples of Development-in-Place Stretch Assignments

Challenge	Reshape Your Job	Temporary Assignment
Unfamiliar Responsibilities	Ask your boss to delegate one of his or her job responsibilities to you.	Take on part of a colleague's job while he or she is on temporary leave.
New Directions	Be responsible for a new project or new process in your group.	Join a project team that is plowing new ground in your organization.
Inherited Problems	Be responsible for dealing with dissatisfied customers or difficult suppliers.	Redesign a flawed product or system.
Problems With Employees	Coach employees with performance problems in your group.	Resolve a conflict with a direct report.
High Stakes	Manage an annual organizational event with high visibility.	Do a tight-deadline assignment for your boss.
Scope and Scale	Serve on multiple project teams simultaneously.	Join a team managing a large-scale project.
External Pressure	Add external interface roles to your job.	Take calls on a customer hotline.
Influencing Without Authority	Manage projects that require coordination across the organization.	Represent concerns of employees to higher management.
Work Across Cultures	Serve as the liaison with a business partner in another country.	Work in a short-term assignment at an office in another country.
Work Group Diversity	Train regularly in your company's diversity program.	Lead a project team with a diverse group of members.

Adapted from McCauley (2006).

Build a Framework

One of the best ways to encourage the use of stretch experiences in leadership development is to make them more prominent. Leaders are often given a list of classes they can take for their development. They are less likely to receive a list of stretch experiences to consider pursuing. Any one of several challenging assignment frameworks can serve as a foundation for generating such lists (e.g., Kizilos, 2012; Lombardo & Eichinger, 2002; McCauley, 2006). Table 8.2 illustrates how such a framework can be used to generate examples of development-in-place opportunities in an organization.

Practitioners also emphasize the importance of stretch experiences by featuring them as a foundational element in the organization's leadership development strategy. For example, in Payless Holdings' leadership success profile, experiences needed for success are highlighted alongside the more common articulation of important leader attributes and competencies (Boyd, 2014). An experience-driven development strategy starts with the business strategy and the kinds of capabilities needed to realize that strategy, then identifies the experiences needed to develop the capabilities and the relationships needed to challenge and support learning from those experiences (Yost & Plunkett, 2009). The resulting "developmental map" can then be integrated into succession planning, training, and performance management processes so that leaders can pursue needed stretch experiences.

Highlight Stretch Experiences in Formal Development Programs

Formal development programs are an ideal setting to highlight and reinforce learning from stretch experiences. These programs are pervasive in organizations; those participating are already oriented toward learning and development; and perhaps most importantly, formal programs provide a space to practice learning from experience in a supportive environment.

The design of effective development programs has long emphasized the important role of experiential learning. Not only must participants be exposed to useful knowledge and perspectives, but they must also have the opportunity to apply the knowledge to real-life situations, practice skills, and generate their own insights from engaging in experiences. Thus, these programs feature elements such as using a new framework to diagnose and discover potential solutions to back-home challenges, practicing skills and receiving feedback via role plays and simulations, and engaging in and debriefing group exercises to generate new insights about oneself and working with others. What is critical from a learning agility perspective is emphasizing how the same learning tactics being utilized in the program—like experimenting with new approaches to a problem, practicing and getting feedback, and jumping into an experience then debriefing that experience with others—can be used for continuous learning from day-to-day experiences.

Formal programs designed to extend over time offer additional opportunities to access new stretch experiences and to emphasize learning from

these experiences. For example, program participants can work in teams on action learning projects, accomplishing real work in the organization that stretches them to work in ways that are more strategic, cross functional, and innovative. At the same time, these teams are supported by coaches who interject and encourage learning in the midst of action via productive dialogue, reflection, and intentional experimentation (O'Neill & Marsick, 2007). Back-home learning projects can also be individualized. For example, in a program at Duke University for employees interested in moving into a management role, participants' supervisors agree to delegate one of their own job responsibilities to the participant during the course of the program (Allison & Green, 2014). And at Heineken, a program for first-time supervisors is structured as a continuous learning group where participants bring current challenges to gain insights from both facilitated discussion with others and modularized content most relevant to the challenge (Plunkett & Daubner, 2014).

Reinforce Learning From Experience as a Core Organizational Value

It is important to note that moving beyond practicing to regularly engaging in stretch experiences requires an organizational culture that values learning from experience and that tolerates the inevitable mistakes that leaders will make. How are such values communicated and reinforced? First, they are communicated through the actions of senior executives, for example, in the way they share their own experiences of learning from stretch experiences, who they tap for visible assignments, and how they react to missteps during these assignments. Second, valuing learning from experience is reinforced by what is recognized and rewarded in the organization. Are people rewarded for stepping to the edge of their comfort zone—even if their performance takes an initial dip as they are learning to deal with new challenges? Are they discouraged from pursuing a lateral move to broaden their perspective because such a move does not offer the same financial rewards as a promotion in their own function? Values are also communicated by what is measured and tracked in the organization. For example, if an organization evaluates the impact of its formal leadership development programs, but not the impact of its use of stretch assignments for development, it could be sending the message that it values and supports formal learning over learning from experience. Finally, values are reinforced by how the organization invests its

Table 8.3 Strategies for Making Stretch Experiences Happen in Organizations

Educate and Support Bosses	Staff for Development	Design New Stretch Experiences
• Recognize each direct reports' development needs • Use job moves, new responsibilities, and temporary assignments to create stretch experiences • Manage the risk of stretch assignments	• Identify stretch roles in succession management discussions • Highlight stretch experiences in formal development plans • Use rotational assignments beyond early career • Designate particular positions or team roles as developmental assignments • Create project marketplaces	• Create short-term assignments to equip more leaders with strategic competencies • Surround the experiences with learning resources: learning goals, coaching, formal training, and reflection

resources. Can a leader struggling in a stretch assignment readily access resources for a professional coach? To what degree is the organization willing to invest in attracting and retaining learning agile leaders?

Make Stretch Experiences Happen

Highly learning agile individuals will find ways to make stretch experiences happen on their own. However, the majority of people will benefit from organizational settings where stretch opportunities are readily available and where there is support for discerning which experiences are best for targeted development. Also, by making stretch experiences more readily available, organizations reduce the risk of losing talented leaders who might see greater opportunities with another employer. To make the right kind of stretch experiences happen for more people, organizations need to take a look at the role of bosses, the organization's staffing practices, and opportunities to create new stretch experiences (Table 8.3).

Equip Bosses to Use Stretch Experiences

In most organizations, a key managerial responsibility is developing direct reports in ways that enhance current and future performance. Yet, very few

of these organizations actually teach bosses—the people who control access to many stretch experiences—how to use these experiences to develop leaders while accomplishing work. A little education can equip these managers with the basics to more proactively use job assignments to develop their direct reports (Box 8.1). These managers need to know how to identify an individual's strengths and weaknesses and recognize what kind of challenges will create stretch opportunities that target underdeveloped competencies. For example, serving on a cross-functional team is an opportunity to develop a broader framework for understanding organization issues and learn how to coordinate action across silos. Bosses also need to understand their role in applying common strategies for accessing stretch experiences: job moves, temporary assignments, reshaping current job responsibilities, and experiences outside the workplace in professional and community organizations. For example, does the manager keep an eye on open positions in the organization for individuals who are ready for their next big challenge, think about who will grow most from representing the function on a task force or making a presentation to higher management, consider shifting responsibilities among team members to develop more people with broader capabilities, and encourage direct reports to consider leadership roles in volunteer organizations?

Education for bosses should also generate discussion about the risks in inviting or pushing individuals to the edge of their comfort zone and strategies for mitigating those risks. Risks include poor performance, making mistakes, and endangering the success of critical work in the organization. The individual could become overly stressed, lose confidence in themselves, or derail their career. The bigger the stretch is, the greater the risks. Thus, for major stretch experiences, bosses need to consider what the individual will bring to the experience that can mitigate the risk: Has the individual regularly demonstrated an ability and willingness to learn from stretch experiences? Has the individual demonstrated potential for more complex work? Does the individual have a particular strength or expertise that will clearly contribute to success in the assignment? Contextual aspects of the experience can also mitigate risk: Will the individual be working with a talented team or have ready access to coaching and feedback from an experienced manager? The boss can directly mitigate risks by helping individuals set learning goals, ensuring that they have access to learning resources and feedback, being a sounding board, and asking questions to encourage reflection. Bosses need to guard against the sink-or-swim approach, that is, giving tough assignments as a

Box 8.1 Supporting Learning at the Edge: The Boss's Checklist

Take Responsibility for Developing Your Employees

- ☐ I make developing my employees a core part of my job.
- ☐ I look for ways to support employees in their efforts to learn and grow.
- ☐ I hold employees accountable for their development.

Use On-the-Job Experiences to Develop Employees

- ☐ I ensure that my employees' development plans go beyond formal programs to include on-the-job experiences.
- ☐ I make a point of identifying stretch assignments for each of my direct reports.
- ☐ I give direct reports assignments or experiences to help them develop specific competencies.
- ☐ I create new roles or job responsibilities to provide an employee with needed experience.
- ☐ I consider the development opportunities a particular assignment could provide when making decisions about how to staff key projects.
- ☐ I support employees who seek growth experiences outside the workplace (e.g., in community or professional organizations).
- ☐ I reserve certain types of assignments specifically for employee development.

Support Learning From Experience

- ☐ I help direct reports set goals for learning from stretch assignments, relationships, and formal coursework.
- ☐ I help direct reports assess progress toward learning goals.
- ☐ I give developmental feedback to direct reports.
- ☐ I have conversations with direct reports about what they are learning from their stretch experiences.
- ☐ I help direct reports connect with others who can support their learning and development (e.g., coaches, experts, peer mentors).

test and leaving individuals to fend for themselves. This approach not only discourages less courageous individuals from stepping to the edge of their comfort zone but also reinforces a message that demonstrating competence is more important than growing from the experience.

Staff for Development

Organizations typically approach the task of filling jobs and special assignments with the goal of finding the person who is most capable of high performance given the responsibilities of the job. Staffing for performance aims to maximize person–job fit. On the other hand, staffing for development requires some amount of person–job misfit to create a stretch experience. In the previous section, we noted how this type of misfit is what bosses need to strive for in making local staffing decisions with development in mind. This same approach can be used in formal talent management processes to make more stretch experiences happen.

Numerous talent management practices afford opportunities to staff for development. Decisions about job moves and special assignments, particularly for leaders who are recognized as high potentials, are often made as part of *succession management processes*. Typically, one or more stretch opportunities that target specific development needs are identified for each high potential. *Formal development planning* processes can highlight specific opportunities for stretch experiences in every leader's job and stimulate development conversations between managers and employees. *Rotational programs* typically move early career employees through a set of assignments designed to broaden their business knowledge and organizational networks, grow management skills, and develop a deeper understanding of organizational culture. Some organizations use rotational programs for more experienced leaders. These programs, like GE's Corporate Leadership Staff (Tisoczki & Bevier, 2014) and the US Intelligence Community's Joint Duty Program (Kolmstetter, 2014), customize the rotation experience to individual needs and often have the additional goal of enhancing collaboration across organizational boundaries. An advantage of using organization-wide talent management processes to leverage job experiences for development is the opportunity to monitor and enhance consistency in access to stretch experiences across social identity groups.

Special staffing policies can also support staffing for development. For example, organizations might designate particular roles as developmental

assignments for high potentials. These are demanding jobs with clear performance expectations; however, labeling them as “developmental” sets the expectation that attention should also be given to learning, and designating them as “assignments” signals that they are flow-through positions that are more readily available as stretch experiences. Another example is regularly staffing certain types of core work in the organization that is accomplished by temporary teams, such as process improvement initiatives or new product launches, with development in mind. In other words, reserve at least one spot on the team for someone who can gain developmental benefits from the experience.

A common problem with staffing for development is that many potential stretch experiences can be missed because managers and their direct reports are only aware of the short-term, project-based opportunities in their immediate area of the organization. Intranet-based project marketplaces are a remedy for this dilemma (Davis, 2007). Projects looking for part-time help on certain tasks or in need of particular skills, short-term assignments, and jobs needed to be filled on an interim basis are posted; people from across the organization can learn about these opportunities and decide with their manager whether pursuing one of the posted assignments would have benefits.

Design New Stretch Experiences

What organizations quickly learn as they are working to leverage on-the-job experiences for development is that there are not enough of the right stretch experiences to develop certain competencies widely in the organization (e.g., a global perspective, strategic thinking, or cross-boundary collaboration). So, they find ways to create new stretch experiences where there were none. Let us take a look at some examples.

Born out of the need for a more globally savvy and responsible organization, IBM's Corporate Service Corps (CSC) uses international volunteering to develop leaders' business knowledge and global perspective while advancing business objectives (Flaherty & Osicki, 2014). At the core of the CSC experience is a 1-month assignment as part of a global team providing pro bono IBM expertise for organizations in disadvantaged, developing parts of the world. For 3 months prior to the on-the-ground experience, the team prepares together virtually—learning about their host country and consulting tactics, building the team, and identifying personal learning goals. After the experience, participants share their experience and insights with

the company and in their local communities. Participants report that this demanding experience develops a number of capabilities, with collaborating globally, embracing challenge, and building mutual trust at the top of the list.

With emerging markets growing rapidly, Microsoft needed to grow in-country talent with a broad perspective on corporate business practices (Bhasin, Homer, & Rait, 2014). The organization designed an initiative that brought recognized local talent in emerging markets to corporate headquarters for a 3-month assignment on a project that both capitalized on their extensive knowledge of field operations and provided a tailored opportunity to fill a leadership gap. An opportunity profile clarified the assignment, identified a sponsor and day-to-day manager, and articulated the experience to be gained and competencies to be developed. Three elements supported a positive learning experience: intensive onboarding, an external coach, and an intentional reentry process that emphasized sharing lessons learned in the participants' local organization. Measuring the impact of the program found benefits not only for the participant but also for the corporate host organization (e.g., gaining a field perspective on major projects) and the home location (e.g., increasing knowledge of doing business at Microsoft).

In both of these examples, short-term assignments were created to give more leaders a stretch experience aimed at developing capabilities the organization needed to realize its strategic intents. The assignments also served purposes beyond individual development (e.g., corporate social responsibility, bringing field expertise to corporate projects). Perhaps most importantly, development was supported by surrounding the experience with learning resources, such as learning goals, coaching, formal training, and the opportunity to reflect on the experience and share insights gained with others.

Encourage the Practice of Daily Learning From Stretch Experiences

Developmental challenges can encompass the full job (e.g., turning a business around), but they can also be small, daily on-the-job challenges that promote continuous development (Sessa & London, 2015). Expertise in any field requires deliberate practice (Ericsson, Prietula, & Cokely, 2007). Learning to play the piano, for example, does not start with a Bach concerto, but instead begins with finger positions, scales, and learning to read musical

notation. Why would something as complicated as working with others on ever-shifting challenges to accomplish the strategic aims of an organization be any less difficult?

But, development does not happen automatically, and leaders often miss the opportunity to extract learning from their daily work. People need to develop habits and practices that allow them to self-manage their learning; that is, they need to anticipate, adapt, and reflect on the developmental challenges they face (Ashford & DeRue, 2012). Considerable research suggests that people tend to rely on simple rules (heuristics) to make most decisions rather than engage in active cognitive processing, what Kahneman (2011) called System 1 versus System 2 thinking. He suggested that knowing the errors in one's thinking is not the magic solution—people still make the same mistakes. One potential way to sidestep the problem is to adopt better heuristics.

Consequently, the trick may be to provide leaders with a set of heuristics that promotes growth within developmental assignments. To have the maximum impact, the heuristic should be grounded in research, simple, habit forming, and self-reinforcing so that learning behaviors become self-sustaining (Duhigg, 2012; Yost, 2016). Eight heuristics that leaders can use to anticipate, adapt, and reflect on their daily development are discussed next and summarized in Figure 8.1.

Anticipating

One of the first tasks is to create the conditions that frame the stretch experience and cue the leader to see the developmental opportunities as they emerge.

Ask “What’s My Story Today?” One anticipatory strategy is to frame the developmental challenge in a way that is motivating. People adopt a variety of narratives to understand their work experiences (Yost, Yoder, Chung, & Voetmann, 2015). An upcoming tough conversation can be seen as a potential tragedy, transformational moment, or just another existential moment in the meaninglessness of work. However, the stories that people tell themselves can have a powerful impact on the types of challenges they are willing to take on, the effort they will expend, and how long they are willing to persist (Ibarra & Barbulescu, 2010). One of the most powerful narratives is what Joseph Campbell (2008) called the hero’s journey, a common type of story arc that crosses time and culture. In this narrative arc, the hero leaves the village, faces challenges and adversaries to overcome, ultimately requiring

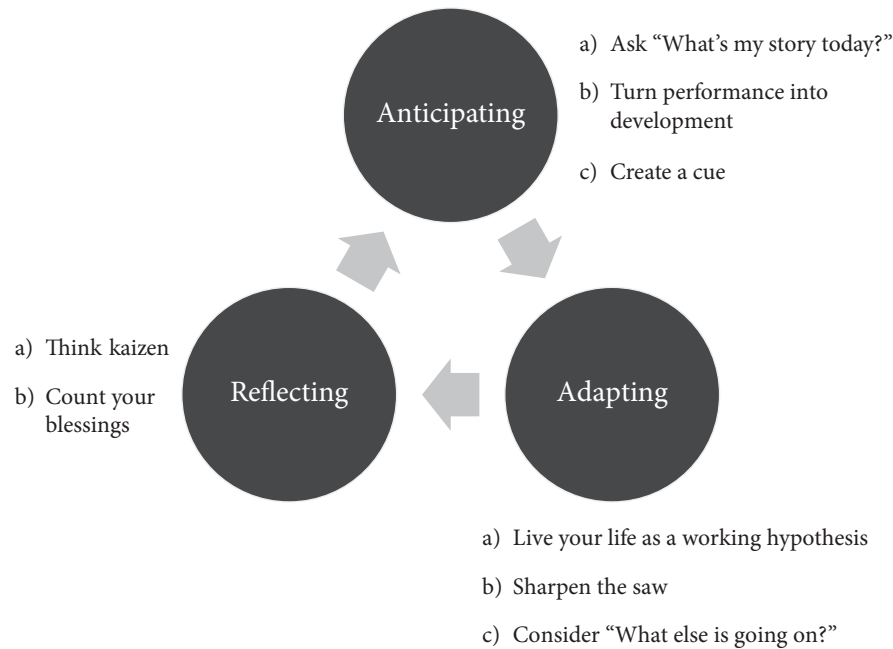


Figure 8.1 Strategies to encourage the practice of daily learning from stretch assignments.

conquering his or her own internal weaknesses to arrive at a new horizon. The power of this narrative is that it assumes challenges will come, they are a good thing, and they must be overcome to get to a better future. In this way, Carol Dweck’s (2006) research on the power of a growth mindset builds on this and suggests that the framing of challenges is important. Developmental challenges should not be seen as evaluations of one’s fixed abilities but as opportunities to grow. Developmental challenges inevitably come with successes and failure. In her TED Talk, Dweck (2014) suggested that in these moments of failure, it is important to adopt a heuristic that focuses on growth. The self-talk should not be, “I’m not good at this.” Instead, the focus should be on the developmental journey, “Am I good at this? Not yet.”

Turn Performance Into Development. A second anticipatory strategy is to bundle development with performance. Work is often seen through two lenses—performance versus development—that are considered to be in tension. They do not have to be. If the vast majority of a person’s development happens on the job, then they can and do happen at the same time. The trick is to strategically place oneself in situations that are developmental and drive the business (Yost & Plunkett, 2009). For example, a person can volunteer to

manage the team's budget to develop financial acumen. An emerging leader can take the lead in onboarding new employees to learn how to motivate and support others. A senior leader can enhance his or her strategic thinking by helping direct reports wrestle with the long-term implications of their decisions.

Create a Cue. A final anticipatory strategy is to create an environment that cues development. The external environment can have a profound impact on a person's behavior. This can result in two possible conclusions. First, the world around us controls us or we have control to craft an environment that guides us in the direction we want to go (Duckworth, Gendler, & Gross, 2016). The second is a lot more empowering. Cues are a powerful way to direct attention (Hofmann, Friese, & Strack, 2009) and can become implementation intentions (Gollwitzer, 1999) that promote growth and on-the-job development. For example, one leader might post his development goals above his computer. Another might paste a green dot on her computer to remind her that her goal in every email will be to delegate and equip people to do the work themselves. Another person might build in time at the beginning of a meeting for the team to reflect on "lessons learned" during the week. The possibilities are endless.

Adapting

The world seldom unfolds as predicted. Thus, it is equally important for organizations to help leaders navigate and capture learning in the moment. Several strategies are important during the experience to increase learning.

Live Your Life as a Working Hypothesis. The first adaptive strategy that leaders can adopt is to frame the experience as an experiment. In dynamic environments, a person needs to figure out what to do in the moment. Days will be filled with both wins and losses. It is important to develop the capacity to not simply react, but to actively learn in the moment, considering multiple futures and outcomes and testing them to create new insights about oneself and the world (Karoly, 1993). Dynamic environments require stepping into the unknown to learn what works and what does not. Rather than trying to execute a new leadership skill perfectly, leaders can break the skills they are trying to develop into smaller chunks. They can prototype smaller actions (e.g., contracting with smaller clients) in ways that succeed or fail in bigger projects (e.g., contracting with major clients). Like in design thinking, the

development and risk are broken into smaller chunks (Brown, 2008; Rigby, Sutherland, & Takeuchi, 2016). Over time, development happens incrementally. People build on small wins to increase confidence and adapt their performance in complex, dynamic environments (Weick, 1984). In this way, organizations build cultures where people can learn to “fail fast” and iteratively build complex skill sets (Van Dyck, Frese, Baer, & Sonnentag, 2005). They develop agile learning capabilities and expertise that generalize to future challenges.

Sharpen the Saw. A second adaptive strategy is to ensure one takes the time to recharge. Daily challenges require energy, resilience, and persistence. In *Seven Habits of Highly Effective People* (1990), Stephen Covey’s seventh habit is “sharpening the saw,” suggesting that people will eventually become less and less effective, like an unsharpened saw, if they do not take time to rest and retool. Subsequent research has confirmed the importance of several habits in long-term well-being and effectiveness, including exercise, meditation or prayer, sleep, and social support (e.g., Tabibnia & Radecki, 2018). Setting aside time to recharge takes discipline, but it is a requirement for continuous development.

Ask “What Else Is Going On?” A final adaptive strategy is to step onto the balcony to assess the broader context. Challenging assignments happen in complex environments. In his book *Humble Inquiry*, Ed Schein (2013) suggested that a critical question that consultants should always ask is, “What else is going on?” There are always multiple dynamics at play. Asking the question allows people to see the system from multiple perspectives. They move from the dance floor to the balcony (Heifetz & Laurie, 2001) to develop more complex and adaptive ways of understanding themselves and the world (Kegan, 1994).

Reflecting

Lessons are not automatically captured when a challenge ends. The potential lessons need to be identified, remembered, and applied to future situations.

Think Kaizen. The first step of reflection in the moment is to remember that development is iterative and continuous. In the golden age of lean manufacturing and Six Sigma, the Japanese manufacturing concept of “kaizen” or continuous improvement was introduced (Imai, 1986). Because the development of complex behaviors is an iterative process, it is important to create daily opportunities to reflect on and lock in changes. Team huddles

can be used at the beginning and end of a process to capture lessons and plan for the next day (Rigby et al., 2016). Daily on-the-job development opportunities can be enhanced with after-event reviews to explore what happened, why it happened, and what to do differently the next time (DeRue, Nahrgang, Hollenbeck, & Workman, 2012). In these reflection moments, the focus should be on learning, not blame. And, for heaven's sake, make sure people do not call them postmortems; no one wants to take time to revisit a dead project.

Count Your Blessings. The second important reflection strategy is to take the time to celebrate along the way. Small wins build confidence, which in turn improves future performance. Celebration might include reflecting at the end of the day about three things one is grateful for, celebrating milestone accomplishments, or expressing gratitude to colleagues with a quick thank you note (Lyubomirsky, Sheldon, & Schkade, 2005). Research suggests that these practices not only are good for the person, but also are infectious to the people around the person, who are more likely to engage in prosocial behavior themselves.

Encouraging Daily Learning Across the Organization

The anticipating, adapting, and reflecting heuristics that we have just reviewed are largely individual actions. However, the goal should be to introduce interventions that target individuals yet can spread across the organization to promote growth throughout the whole system. This should include building on-the-job development into human resource processes (Yost & Plunkett, 2010), such as emphasizing on-the-job development in the performance management process or training interventions and during job transitions when people are particularly open to learning new habits. Another way to increase the attention might include introducing a 30-day challenge with daily activities to increase on-the-job development (Preston-Dayne, 2014). Similarly, an organization might introduce a "development minute" that supervisors can discuss at the beginning of staff meetings (e.g., "This week's development minute is asking, 'Who's voice is missing?' so let's practice making sure no one dominates and everyone's voice can be heard."). Organizations will maximize development when they find ways to make daily learning an integral part of the culture.

Future Directions

When it comes to developing individuals in work settings, the last 30 years have brought increased attention to the importance of stretch experiences, yielded research-based insights about learning from these experience, and generated new practices in organizations aimed at leveraging experiences for development (McCauley & McCall, 2014). Moving forward, we see opportunities to expand the impact of this work and deepen our understanding of learning agility.

Perhaps the most progress from a practice perspective has been in those arenas where talent development professionals have direct influence, for example, the design of development programs, the facilitation of succession management discussions, and the creation of targeted development interventions to support the strategic needs of the organization. However, the fact that stretch experiences are woven into the ongoing work of the organization means that much of learning from stretch experiences is in the hands of leaders and their managers. Although tackling this dilemma from a cultural change perspective is possible (with enlightened senior executives and a powerful talent development function), we have been inspired by practitioners who have found ways to enhance experience-based learning in the organization from whatever role they happen to be in without waiting to be part of a large strategic initiative (Yost & Plunkett, 2010). Experimentation with tactics and tools for educating and encouraging leaders across the organization to seek out and learn from stretch experiences needs to continue, and insights gained from this work need to be more broadly shared in professional circles (McCauley, DeRue, Yost, & Taylor, 2014).

The emergence of the learning agility construct has in many ways energized the learning-from-experience movement in organizations, particularly in the context of leadership development. However, we do see a downside to the construct being too closely tied to the identification and advancement of high potentials. Although some facets of learning agility measures (see Chapter 1) are clearly related to the learning process (e.g., experimenting, feedback responsiveness), other facets appear more important for advancing to higher level management jobs in the organization (e.g., inspiring others, cognitive perspective). We would advocate for frameworks that better delineate the basics of learning agility—those competencies that help anyone step into and learn at the edge of their comfort zone—and the more advanced

facets of learning agility for moving into more complex and strategic roles in organizations.

From a research perspective, we suggest that stretch experiences are a fruitful setting for discovering more about learning agility and how it impacts leadership development and performance. Following individuals over time during these experiences would yield more insights about the positive and negative dynamics of stretch experiences and the role of learning agility and contextual factors on any developmental gains. Experimental studies of interventions aimed to increase learning agility in the context of stretch experiences would also be beneficial.

Another promising area for additional research is identification of the facets of learning agility that are most important for maximizing learning from different stretch experiences. In the spirit of the original lessons of experience research that identified the unique pattern of lessons tied to each type of experience (McCall et al., 1988), research could identify the facets of learning agility that are most critical for learning from different experiences. For example, Lombardo and Eichinger (2002) identified experiences to develop a given competency. Similarly, McKenna, Boyd, and Yost (2007) used the original lessons of experience methodology to build a matrix of stretch assignments and learning agility dimensions for church clergy. Future research could more systematically assess which dimensions moderate the relationships between experiences and leadership growth for different types of stretch assignments or identify a subset of dimensions critical in all stretch assignments. Finally, significantly more work is needed to identify the daily incremental stretch moments that grow a leader and the critical role that learning agility plays in facilitating continuous growth.

In organizations today where change seems to be the rule and stability the exception, stretch experiences are plentiful. Organizations would be wise to equip leaders at all levels with the learning agility skills and capabilities that will allow them to thrive in a world of constant change.

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